

THE INDIAN CYBER FRAUD SURVIVAL PLAYBOOK

Protect your family from digital arrest, UPI, OTP and investment scams - and recover your money in the golden hour.

WHAT THIS IS

A field manual for the 12 scams emptying Indian bank accounts in 2026, the prevention settings that lock your money down, and the exact recovery steps to follow in the first 60 minutes after a fraud.

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How to use this playbook

Read Parts 1 and 2 once, so you recognise a scam while it is happening. Keep Part 3 (prevention) for a quiet evening and act on it - it takes about an hour and closes most of the doors. Photograph Section 21 (the 12 red flags) and put it on your fridge and in your parents' phone. If you are reading this in the middle of a fraud, jump straight to Section 31, The Golden Hour.

A note on the law and your money

This is an information product, not legal or financial advice. Every rule, helpline and threshold here is drawn from official Indian sources as of October 2026, but rules change and every case has its own facts. Where a figure matters, the source is named. For your specific case, speak to your bank and, if needed, a lawyer.

Part 1 - The Threat Landscape

Section 1 - Why this is India's most expensive crime

India lost Rs 22,495 crore to cyber fraud in 2025. That is about Rs 62 crore every day, or roughly Rs 43 lakh every hour of the year. In 2021 the annual figure was Rs 551 crore. In four years it grew more than forty times.

The Ministry of Home Affairs, replying in Parliament, put the number of cyber-fraud complaints filed on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP) and the Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS) at over 24 lakh for 2025, up from 2.6 lakh in 2021. The money lost in a single year now exceeds the annual budget of several Indian states.

Year	Complaints on NCRP / CFCFRMS	Amount reported lost
2021	2.6 lakh	Rs 551 crore
2022	6.9 lakh	not separately reported
2023	13.1 lakh	not separately reported
2024	19.2 lakh	about Rs 22,845 crore
2025	over 24 lakh	Rs 22,495 crore

Source: Ministry of Home Affairs replies in Parliament, February 2026; NCRP and CFCFRMS data.

The composition of the loss matters as much as its size. Investment and trading fraud took 76 per cent of all the money Indians lost in 2025. Digital arrest took 9 per cent. Sextortion took 4 per cent. In case numbers the order flips: sextortion was 19 per cent of complaints and digital arrest 6 per cent, because those crimes are reported more often even when smaller sums are involved.

Who is being hit

In 2025 alone, 1,03,488 senior citizens filed cyber-fraud complaints worth Rs 4,005 crore, and 4,63,114 women filed complaints worth Rs 3,765 crore (Ministry of Home Affairs, Rajya Sabha, August 2026). The two groups with the least exposure to the news cycle - the elderly and the first-time smartphone user - are losing the most per person.

Four forces keep pushing the number up. First, the sheer scale of digital payments: UPI now moves money for crores of households, and every account is a door. Second, organised crime: many of these frauds are run like call centres, with trained scripts, fake uniforms and layered mule accounts, often from compounds outside India. Third, silence: many victims never report, because of shame, so the fraudster's cost of finding the next target stays near zero. Fourth, AI: deepfaked voices and faces, and chatbots that write flawless English, have cut the cost of a convincing scam to almost nothing.

Section 2 - How the money moves, and why the first hour decides everything

When you transfer money to a fraudster, it does not sit still. It is swept through what the police call mule accounts - bank accounts rented or sold by ordinary people - and then layered: split, re-split and moved across banks, wallets and sometimes crypto, within minutes. The last hop is usually an ATM withdrawal or a purchase, and once cash leaves the system it is effectively gone.

This is why the entire recovery system in India is built around speed. When you report to the 1930 helpline, a ticket is pushed into CFCFRMS, which connects the police with more than 85 banks, payment intermediaries and wallets. Each bank in the chain is asked to put the disputed amount on hold (a lien) before it can be withdrawn. The earlier you report, the more of the money is still sitting in the system to be caught.

What CFCFRMS has done	Figure
Money prevented from reaching fraudsters (Apr 2021 to Nov 2025)	Rs 7,647 crore
Total amount reported by victims in the same period	Rs 52,969 crore
Amount actually restored to victims in that period	about Rs 167 crore (2.18 per cent)
Money saved, cumulative, to 30 June 2026	Rs 11,158 crore, across 32.80 lakh complaints
Restoration completed after the new modules (to Aug 2026)	36,290 cases, about Rs 18.05 crore

Sources: Ministry of Home Affairs SOP for NCRP-CFCFRMS (June 2026); MHA replies in Parliament; Supreme Court order, 4 August 2026.

The gap between money saved (Rs 7,647 crore) and money returned (Rs 167 crore) is the single most important fact in this playbook. Catching the money is only half the job. Getting it back out of a frozen account requires a court order and, usually, a victim who keeps pushing. Sections 33 and 37 show you exactly how to push.

The two things that decide your outcome

1. Speed to 1930. Report within the first one to three hours and your money is likely still in the system. Wait two days and it is usually gone.
2. Persistence afterwards. The freeze happens automatically; the refund does not. Follow the recovery ladder until the money is back in your account.

Section 3 - Why careful, educated people still fall

The people who lose the most money to these scams are not gullible. They are law-abiding, often retired professionals, business owners and senior citizens - people who take an accusation from 'the police' seriously and who do not want to involve their family in something 'official'. The scam does not attack your intelligence. It attacks your emotions, and it does so with four levers.

The lever	How it is used
Authority	A uniform, a badge, a station backdrop, a spoofed caller ID, an official-sounding case number. Authority switches off doubt.
Urgency	Arrest is 'imminent'; the KYC expires 'today'; the offer closes 'in ten minutes'. Urgency removes the time to think.
Fear	Threats of arrest, frozen accounts, passport cancellation or public shame flood the body with alarm, which overrides careful judgement.
Isolation	You are told to keep it secret - 'telling family makes you an accomplice'. One outside opinion would end the scam in seconds, which is exactly why it is forbidden.

Under this much pressure, even a calm person's threat response takes over. That is not weakness; it is how human beings are wired. The defence is therefore not to try harder in the moment - it is to decide the rules in advance, so the decision is already made before the fear arrives.

The antidote to every one of these scams

Pre-commitment. Decide today, in the calm, that (1) no money ever moves during an unexpected call, (2) you will always hang up and verify on a number you found yourself, and (3) you will always tell one other person before you act. A rule made in advance beats a scam made for the moment.

Section 4 - The channels scammers use to reach you

The same frauds arrive through a handful of channels, and each has a tell.

Channel	What to watch for
Phone calls	Spoofed caller IDs that look like a bank, police station or a relative. A familiar number proves nothing - it is trivially faked.
WhatsApp / Telegram	Investment 'VIP groups', task-job offers, fake customer care, sextortion. The most common entry point for money-losing scams.
SMS with links	KYC, bill, parcel and challan messages that carry a link. The link either phishes your details or installs malware.
Social media DMs and ads	Fake profiles, fake job ads and sponsored posts for fake trading platforms.
Fake websites and apps	Look-alike bank and government pages, and side-loaded apps (.apk) that capture your credentials.
Marketplace chats	OLX, Facebook Marketplace and similar, where a 'buyer' or 'seller' turns out to be a fraudster.

Channel	What to watch for
AI voice and video	Cloned voices and deepfaked faces, used to impersonate a relative in trouble or a celebrity endorsing an investment.

Notice what is not on this list: a genuine bank or government body never initiates a criminal allegation, never asks for money to be moved, and never needs your OTP, PIN, password or screen. Whatever the channel, if the request crosses one of those lines, it is a fraud.

Section 5 - What India has built to fight back

The recovery machinery is real, and knowing it exists changes how you behave in a crisis. Almost every piece of it was built in the last five years.

- **I4C (Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre)**, under the Ministry of Home Affairs, coordinates the national response and runs the reporting portals.
- **NCRP and 1930.** The National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and the 1930 helpline are the two front doors for citizens.
- **CFCFRMS** links the police to more than 85 banks, wallets and payment firms so money can be frozen in real time. By 30 June 2026, 1,586 entities - including 40 foreign banks - were onboarded.
- **The Suspect Registry** (launched 10 September 2024) shares known fraud identifiers with banks. By 30 June 2026 it had circulated 30.48 lakh suspect identifiers and 32.08 lakh first-layer mule accounts, and helped decline transactions worth Rs 25,698 crore.
- **Blocking at scale.** By 30 June 2026, more than 15.75 lakh SIM cards and 5.77 lakh IMEIs had been blocked, and 3,718 fraudulent apps (including loan apps) had been taken down.
- **The Money Restoration Module and Grievance Redressal Module**, made functional in April 2026, exist specifically to return frozen money to victims and to fix wrongly frozen accounts.
- **Chakshu**, on the DoT's Sanchar Saathi portal, lets you report a fraud number so it can be disconnected for everyone.

In August 2026 the Supreme Court, hearing a case on digital-arrest scams, directed all states and courts to operationalise these restoration modules and told the RBI to issue banks a standard procedure for holding fraud-linked amounts. In other words, the system is being pushed to work faster - but it only works if you plug into it, and quickly.

Part 2 - Know the 12 Scams

Section 6 - Digital arrest: the script, and the one line that ends it

There is no such thing as a digital arrest in Indian law. No agency - not the police, not the CBI, the ED, Customs, the RBI or the Income Tax Department - arrests anyone over a phone or video call, or asks a citizen to transfer money to prove their innocence. Every digital-arrest call is a fraud, and it ends the moment you hang up.

This scam is built on fear, authority, urgency and isolation. It is run in four stages, and knowing them is half the defence.

Stage	What the caller does	Your move
1. The hook	A call or recorded message: a parcel in your name seized with drugs, a SIM misused, your account flagged for money laundering.	Recognise the pattern. No courier, bank or telecom company starts a criminal allegation by phone.
2. The handover	You are 'transferred' to a senior officer - a uniform, a badge, a backdrop that looks like a police station - who places you under 'digital arrest'.	Real transfers do not happen to 'senior officers'. This is theatre.
3. The isolation	You are told to stay on camera and tell no one, because 'telling family makes you an accomplice'.	This is the engine of the con. Break it: hang up and call a family member.
4. The extraction	Relentless pressure - arrest is 'imminent' - until you transfer money to a 'safe account' or pay 'bail' or a 'security deposit'.	Never transfer money to prove innocence. No real investigation works that way.

Indians lost an estimated Rs 2,140 crore to digital-arrest fraud over an 18-month period, and digital arrest accounted for 9 per cent of the total money lost to cyber fraud in 2025. Cities reported sharp spikes - Mumbai alone around Rs 155 crore in a year.

The exact words that end the call

Say nothing, argue with nothing. Hang up. Then, if you want certainty, call the police on 100 or the cyber helpline on 1930 and ask them directly. A genuine officer will never mind the call; a fake one is already gone.

A minute-by-minute anatomy of a digital-arrest call

Minute	What happens	What it is designed to do
0-1	A recorded or live message: a parcel, a SIM, or an account linked to a crime.	Hook you with an official-sounding problem.
1-3	You are 'transferred' to a 'senior officer' who appears on video in a uniform.	Replace doubt with the appearance of authority.
3-10	Fake documents, a case number, and a threat of immediate arrest.	Flood you with fear so you stop thinking clearly.
10-30	You are told to stay on camera and tell no one.	Isolate you from anyone who would spot the scam.
30-60+	A demand to transfer money to a 'safe' or 'verification' account to prove innocence.	Convert your fear into a payment before you calm down.

Read that column on the right once, and the whole structure becomes obvious: every step exists to move you from a calm person to a frightened payer. The moment you name the technique, it stops working.

What genuine agencies never do: they never call you first to accuse you, never keep you on a video call, never forbid you from telling family or a lawyer, never ask you to transfer money to a 'government', 'RBI', 'verification' or 'safe' account, and never ask for OTPs, PINs, passwords or screen access. Any one of these means it is a scam - full stop.

The law is catching up. In July 2026 the Centre told the Supreme Court it is preparing a Bill to make digital arrest and AI-generated deepfakes distinct offences with their own punishments, after the Court noted that existing penal laws do not define them. Until that law is in force, digital-arrest cases are booked under the general cheating and impersonation provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Information Technology Act (Section 40).

Section 7 - Investment and trading scams: the biggest loss-maker

Investment fraud is where the most money goes - 76 per cent of every rupee Indians lost to cyber fraud in 2025, and 35 per cent of all cases. The pitch is always the same: guaranteed returns, a 'VIP' trading group on WhatsApp or Telegram, a slick app showing your profits climbing, and a small first withdrawal that works to build trust.

Then the door closes. When you try to take out a larger amount, you are told to pay a 'tax', a 'conversion fee' or a 'margin' first. You pay. The withdrawal never comes. Some platforms are fake apps; some are real trading apps used with a fake 'manager' who controls your account; and increasingly the promotion uses deepfaked videos of well-known business leaders and market experts to look credible.

The five tells of an investment scam

Any promise of 'guaranteed', 'assured' or 'fixed' high returns - no genuine market investment can promise this.

You are pushed to a link or app shared inside a chat, never to a platform you found and verified yourself.

You are asked to pay a fee or tax to release your own withdrawal.

The profits on the screen are large, but the money is never actually in your bank account.

The people running it are always 'too busy' to talk on video except in polished recordings.

Before investing a rupee, check that the platform or adviser is registered. Mutual funds, brokers and investment advisers are registered with SEBI, and you can verify any of them on the SEBI website. Banks and non-banking finance companies are regulated by the RBI. If the person urging you to invest cannot show a registration you verified yourself, walk away.

Why the money on the screen is not real

The dashboard that shows your 'profits' climbing is just a number on a screen the fraudster controls. It is not connected to any real market, and it is not connected to your bank. This is the core of the trick: you watch a balance grow while your actual money has already left your account. A real investment has a contract note, a folio or a demat credit you can see in your own accounts - a fake one has only an app that says you are rich. The test is simple: can you move a small amount back into your own bank account whenever you like? If the answer is 'only after I pay something', it is a fraud.

Section 8 - UPI fraud: the QR code and 'collect request' trap

UPI fraud turns on one confusion: people do not know the difference between paying and receiving. Remember this single rule - your UPI PIN is needed only to send money out, never to receive money in. To receive money you need to do nothing at all; the sender enters their own PIN on their side.

Every UPI QR code is a request to pay. There is no such thing as a QR code that credits money to you. So when a marketplace buyer, a courier, a 'refund' agent or a customer-care executive tells you to scan a QR code or enter your PIN to receive a refund, cashback, lottery win or buyer's payment, they are asking you to send them money instead.

What changed in October 2025

NPCI, which runs UPI, stopped person-to-person 'collect requests' from 1 October 2025 (circular NPCI/UPI/OC/220/2025-26, dated 29 July 2025). The old 'approve this request to receive money' scam used that feature. But fraud did not stop - it moved to payment links, QR codes, fake screenshots and remote-access apps, which is why the PIN rule still matters.

Five things to check before you approve any UPI payment: is the screen asking you to pay or receive; does the receiver's name match who you think you are paying; did the request come from someone you know; is anyone rushing you; and did anyone ask you to install an app first. If you cannot answer all five comfortably, stop.

Section 9 - OTP, KYC and 'bank officer' calls

Your one-time password is the last lock on your money. No bank, wallet, telecom company or government office will ever ask you to read out an OTP, a PIN, a password or a card's CVV. If someone asks for any of these, the call is a fraud, however official the caller ID looks - caller IDs are trivially faked.

The common scripts: 'your KYC is expiring, update it now or your account will be blocked'; 'there is a suspicious transaction, confirm your details'; 'your SIM will be deactivated, verify your number'; 'you have an unpaid electricity bill, click this link'. Each ends with a request for an OTP, a PIN, or a link that installs an app that reads your messages.

- Never read an OTP aloud, never type it into a link, never forward it.
- Never approve a 'collect request' or enter a PIN to 'verify' or 'reverse' anything.
- Never click a link to 'update KYC'. Open your bank's own app and check there.
- If you are unsure, hang up and call the number printed on your card or passbook.

Section 10 - Task, review and part-time job scams

This one targets students and anyone looking for extra income. It starts with a WhatsApp or Telegram message offering money for simple tasks - liking videos, posting reviews, following accounts. The first few payments (Rs 100, Rs 300) really arrive, which builds trust.

Then the ask changes. To earn more you must join a 'prepaid task' - pay in Rs 5,000, get Rs 6,500 back. You pay. The app shows your balance growing. When you try to withdraw, you are told you need to complete one more task, or pay a 'tax', and the money never returns.

The rule that ends this scam

A real employer pays you; a real employer never asks you to pay first. The moment a 'job' asks you to deposit, top up or invest money to unlock earnings, it is a fraud. There is no genuine work-from-home job that works this way.

Section 11 - Fake customer care and screen-sharing

You have a problem with your order or your account, so you search for the company's helpline, and the top result is a fake number. You call it, and a helpful 'executive' offers to fix everything - if you install a screen-sharing or remote-support app so they can 'see your screen'.

Once that app is on your phone, the fraudster can watch your screen, read your OTP notifications and guide you into approving payments. Never install AnyDesk, TeamViewer, QuickSupport or any similar remote-access app because a caller asks you to. Genuine support never needs to see your screen or your banking app.

Always reach customer care through the company's own app or the number printed on your card, bill or official website - never through a number you found in a search result or a message.

Section 12 - Loan app and instant-loan traps

Instant-loan apps promise money in minutes with no paperwork. The price is your data: the app asks for access to your contacts, photos and messages, and once you borrow a small amount, it demands repayment at extortionate rates and threatens to message your entire contact list with morphed images or lies.

Only borrow from lenders regulated by the RBI, and check the app's developer and privacy permissions before installing. If an app asks for access to your contacts and photos to give you a loan, that is the warning sign, not a formality. The government has been blocking these apps - by 30 June 2026, I4C had blocked 3,718 mobile apps, including fraudulent loan apps, under the IT Act.

Section 13 - Sextortion

Sextortion is one of the most reported cyber crimes in India - about 19 per cent of all cases in 2025, though only 4 per cent of the money lost. It usually starts with an unsolicited video call from an unknown number. The caller records you, then threatens to send the recording to your family and contacts unless you pay.

Paying almost never ends it; it marks you as someone who pays. If this has happened to you, you are not the one who did something wrong, and you are not alone - thousands of Indians, most of them men, face this every month. Do not pay. Stop all contact. Report it: call 1930 or file at cybercrime.gov.in, where such cases are handled with special focus and confidentiality. Tell one person you trust. The shame is the fraudster's tool; taking it away is what breaks the scam.

If you are being sextorted right now

Do not pay, and do not negotiate. Take screenshots of the threats. Call 1930 or file at cybercrime.gov.in (the portal handles these cases with confidentiality). Talk to someone you trust. Preserve the evidence; block the number.

Section 14 - Deepfake and AI-voice impersonation

AI has made impersonation cheap. A fraudster can now clone a few seconds of someone's voice from a social-media video and use it to call a relative in distress, or create a video that looks like a known business leader endorsing an investment. The old defence - 'I would recognise their voice' - no longer holds.

The counter is a simple family habit. Agree on a code word that only your family knows, and agree on one rule: if anyone calls claiming to be a relative in an emergency and asks for money, hang up and call that person back on the number already saved in your phone. A real emergency survives a two-minute callback; a cloned voice does not.

Section 15 - Courier, e-challan, APK and matrimonial scams

A cluster of smaller scams works the same way - a scary or official-looking message that makes you click.

- **Fake parcel / customs:** a message says a parcel in your name contains illegal goods and you must pay a 'clearance fee' or face action. No courier demands money to release a parcel.
- **E-challan and traffic fine:** a message says you have an unpaid fine and a link to pay it. The link downloads a malicious .apk file that can read your messages and banking details. Never install an app from a link.
- **APK files in general:** on Android, an .apk file sent through a chat is the most common way malware gets onto phones. Only install apps from the official Play Store or App Store.
- **Matrimonial and romance fraud:** a relationship built over weeks or months, then a request to 'invest' together, or a sudden emergency needing money. Real affection does not come with a trading platform.

Section 16 - Card, ATM and cheque fraud

Not every fraud happens online. Cards are still skimmed at ATMs and shops, and the money leaves in ways you may not notice until the statement arrives.

- **ATM skimming:** a device fitted over the card slot or keypad copies your card and PIN. Cover the keypad with your hand, use ATMs inside branches or well-lit, busy places, and give the machine a quick tug before using it.
- **Shoulder surfing:** someone watching you enter your PIN. Never let anyone stand close behind you.
- **Card out of sight:** at a restaurant or fuel station, insist on paying at the counter, or watch the terminal. Do not let your card leave your sight.

- **Card-not-present fraud:** your card number, expiry and CVV are used online. This is why you never share a card photo or the CVV with anyone.
- **Switched-off channels:** turn off international use, contactless taps and online use in your bank app when you are not using them.

If a card is lost, cloned or misused, block it instantly in your bank's app or by calling the bank, then follow the Golden Hour steps in Section 31. Under the RBI's 2017 liability rules, prompt reporting can mean zero liability.

Section 17 - Buying and selling online safely

Marketplaces such as OLX and Facebook Marketplace are a favourite hunting ground, because they put strangers into a rushed transaction.

- **The 'I will pay by QR' buyer:** a fake buyer says he will send money, then sends a QR code or a 'collect' request and asks you to scan or enter your PIN. Receiving money never needs your PIN. Decline.
- **The fake payment screenshot:** a buyer sends an image of a 'successful payment' that never reached your account. Wait until the money is visible in your own app before handing anything over.
- **The advance-payment trap:** as a seller, you are asked to pay a 'shipping', 'insurance' or 'refundable' fee first. Genuine buyers do not ask sellers to pay.
- **In-person deals:** meet in a public, well-lit place, and bring someone with you.
- **Fake sellers:** pay only through a channel you can dispute. A seller demanding a direct UPI transfer for a big-ticket item is a red flag.

Section 18 - Business and seller payment scams

If you run a small business, the amounts at stake are larger and the frauds are aimed at your accounts and your suppliers.

- **Vendor or invoice fraud:** a fraudster emails or WhatsApps you, posing as an existing supplier, and asks you to change the bank account for future payments. Confirm any change of bank details by phone, on a number you already hold - never on the number in the new message.
- **Fake purchase order:** a large 'order' arrives, then a request for a processing fee or advance. Real corporate buyers do not ask small sellers to pay to receive an order.
- **The 'overpayment' refund:** a buyer 'pays' you too much and asks you to refund the difference. The original payment was fake or will be reversed; your refund is real.
- **The 'CEO' message:** a message that appears to be from your boss or a director, asking for an urgent transfer. Verify in person or by a known number.
- **Separate the roles:** keep payment approval away from the person an outsider can most easily reach.

Section 19 - Government scheme, subsidy and insurance scams

Whenever a government scheme or a subsidy is in the news, frauds follow it. The pattern is a message that borrows the scheme's name to extract a fee or a link.

- **Fake registration fees:** a message says you must pay a small fee to 'register' for a government benefit or to 'activate' a subsidy. Genuine benefits are never released on payment of a fee.
- **Fake subsidy / DBT messages:** a link claims your subsidy or instalment is pending and asks for bank details or an OTP. Government transfers do not need your OTP.
- **Fake insurance messages:** messages posing as an insurer or LIC, about a 'lapsed policy', a 'maturity refund' or a 'reward'. The Department of Telecommunications has repeatedly flagged fake LIC and insurer communications.
- **The rule:** check the scheme only on its official government portal, and never through a link or a number supplied by the message itself.

Section 20 - Travel, education and job-offer scams

Three more frauds prey on hope - a cheaper trip, a college seat, a job abroad.

- **Travel:** fake booking sites and 'travel agents' offer flights or hotels at a big discount, then vanish, or call later with a 'cancellation refund' that needs your card details. Book through recognised platforms or the airline or hotel directly.
- **Education:** 'agents' promise a guaranteed admission or a foreign seat for an upfront fee. Pay only to the institution through its official channel, and verify the institution exists.
- **Overseas job offers:** a lucrative foreign job with a 'visa processing fee'. I4C has issued advisories on fake job rackets targeting Indian youth. A genuine employer does not make you pay to be hired.
- **The rule:** never pay to get a job, a seat or a visa through an individual's private account.

Section 21 - The 12 red flags (photograph this page)

If you remember nothing else, remember these. Any single one of them means: stop, hang up, and verify through an official channel you found yourself.

- 1 Someone says you are under 'digital arrest' or an investigation over a call or video call.
- 2 You are told to transfer money to a 'safe', 'government', 'RBI' or 'verification' account.
- 3 You are told to keep the matter secret from family or a lawyer.
- 4 Anyone asks for your OTP, UPI PIN, password, CVV or card number - especially read aloud.
- 5 Someone asks you to scan a QR code or enter your PIN to RECEIVE money.
- 6 You are told to install a screen-sharing or remote-access app.
- 7 You are asked to click a link or install an .apk file sent in a message.
- 8 An investment offers 'guaranteed' or 'assured' returns, or asks you to pay a fee to withdraw.
- 9 A 'job' asks you to pay money, top up or invest to earn.

10A caller claims to be your bank, telecom company or a courier and creates sudden urgency.

11A relative is said to be in trouble and needs money - but you cannot reach them normally.

12The person is rushing you, and gets angry when you say you will call back.

The universal response

Hang up. Do not pay. Do not click. Do not install. Call back on a number you looked up yourself. Tell one other person. Then, if money has moved, call 1930 within the hour.

Part 3 - Lock Your Doors (Prevention)

The best fraud is the one that never reaches you. An hour spent on this part is worth more than any recovery effort. Do it once, then revisit it every six months.

Section 22 - Harden your bank account in 30 minutes

- **Turn on every transaction alert.** SMS and email alerts for every debit, however small, are how you catch a fraud on the first transaction instead of the tenth.
- **Set daily transaction limits.** Keep UPI and card limits as low as you can live with. A lower ceiling caps your worst-case loss.
- **Separate your savings from your spending.** Keep the account linked to UPI and cards low on balance, and park savings in a separate account not linked to any payment app.
- **Review your beneficiaries and mandates.** Delete old payees and any auto-debit mandate you do not recognise.
- **Switch off card channels you do not use** - international transactions, contactless taps and online payments can each be turned off in your bank's app until you need them.
- **Set a limit or cooling period for new beneficiaries** if your bank offers it, so a sudden large transfer to a brand-new payee is slowed down.
- **Keep the bank's official fraud helpline number saved** in your phone, so you are not searching for it in a panic.

The 'two-account' habit that saves the most money

Keep a small balance in the account linked to UPI and cards, and hold your savings in a second account that is not linked to any app or card. If a fraudster gets into your payment account, the most they can take is what is in it. This one habit limits the damage of almost every scam in this book.

The settings to change today, in order

- 1 Open your bank's app and turn on alerts for every transaction, however small.
- 2 Lower your UPI and card limits to the smallest amounts you can live with.
- 3 Remove every saved beneficiary and auto-debit mandate you do not recognise.

- 4 Turn off international, contactless and online card channels until you need them.
- 5 Save the bank's fraud helpline in your phone contacts under a name you will find in a hurry.
- 6 Move your savings into an account that is not linked to any app or card.

Section 23 - Harden your phone

- **Update everything.** Turn on automatic updates for your operating system and your banking, UPI, email and messaging apps. Most malware relies on a flaw that a patch already closed.
- **Remove what you do not use.** Delete unknown apps, old .apk files and any app you do not recognise. Check your app list once a month.
- **Audit permissions.** Review which apps have access to SMS, contacts, camera, microphone and especially Accessibility. A payments or utility app should not need to read your messages.
- **Lock the phone** with a PIN or biometric, not a swipe.
- **Do not sideload.** Install apps only from the official Play Store or App Store. Never install an app from a link in a message.
- **Turn on Google Play Protect** (Android) so the phone scans apps for you.
- **Back up.** Keep a recent backup so that if you have to wipe a compromised phone, you lose nothing.

Section 24 - Protect Aadhaar, PAN and DigiLocker

Your Aadhaar and PAN are the keys to opening accounts in your name, so they are prime targets.

- **Lock your Aadhaar biometrics** on the UIDAI portal when you are not using them, and unlock only when needed. This stops fingerprint-based misuse.
- **Check your Aadhaar authentication history** on the UIDAI site to see who has used it and when. Anything you do not recognise is a red flag.
- **Use masked Aadhaar** (the version that hides the last digits) wherever it is accepted.
- **Never share the OTP for DigiLocker or Aadhaar** with anyone - not an agent, not a 'government officer', not a bank caller.
- **Guard your PAN.** Do not send photographs of your PAN card over WhatsApp to unknown parties or 'agents'.

Section 25 - Passwords and two-factor: the 15-minute upgrade

- **Stop reusing passwords.** One leaked password should not open every account. Use a password manager to keep unique ones.
- **Prefer app-based 2FA** (an authenticator app) over SMS codes, where a service offers both. SMS can be intercepted, especially in a SIM-swap attack.

- **Turn on device binding** in your banking app if it is offered, so the account only opens on your registered phone.
- **Change the password on your email first** if anything is compromised - email is the master key to reset everything else.
- **Use a longer passphrase** of three or four unrelated words rather than a short, complex password you will reuse.

Section 26 - SIM swap: protect the number your money depends on

Almost every bank uses your mobile number as a second key - OTPs land there. A SIM-swap attack steals that key. The fraudster convinces your telecom operator to issue a duplicate SIM in your name, and from that moment your calls and OTPs go to them.

- **Watch for the sign:** a sudden, unexplained loss of mobile signal that lasts hours. If it happens, treat it as urgent.
- **Set a SIM PIN** so the physical SIM cannot be moved to another phone and used.
- **Do not share SIM details** or respond to 'SIM will be deactivated' calls with any information.
- **Prefer app-based 2FA** so a stolen SMS is not the only lock.
- **If it happens:** call your operator immediately to block the SIM, call your bank to freeze net banking, and call 1930 if money has moved.

Section 27 - Protecting children and teens online

Young people face their own versions of these frauds: fake giveaways for games and in-app currency, 'free' offers that harvest accounts, online 'friends' who ask for photos or money, and bullying. The stakes are high, so the conversation matters more than any setting.

- **Talk openly** about the specific scams aimed at their age group, without shame - a child who fears being scolded will hide a problem until it is large.
- **Agree the rule:** never send money, never share personal photos, and never share an OTP or password, to anyone online.
- **Turn on parental controls** and privacy settings, and keep the device updated.
- **Report** online sexual abuse material and grooming at cybercrime.gov.in, which handles crimes against women and children with special focus and confidentiality, and to the police.
- **Be reachable.** Make sure they know they can come to you the moment something feels wrong, with no consequences.

Section 28 - A dedicated word for senior citizens

Older Indians lose the most per person, and the three scams that hit hardest are digital arrest, fake investment and fake KYC. If you are a senior citizen - or you care for one - these steps are worth more than any warning poster.

- **Name one trusted person** - a son, daughter, nephew or friend - who you will call before acting on any urgent money request. Write their number on a card by the phone.
- **Keep large sums out of the payment account.** A small balance in the UPI account limits what any scam can take.
- **Remember the sentence:** no genuine officer, bank or company ever asks for money, an OTP or secrecy over a phone call. Say it out loud when you are unsure.
- **Never feel rushed.** You are allowed to hang up and call back. Genuine matters wait; scams cannot.
- **If you have been defrauded, tell someone.** You have done nothing wrong, and reporting fast is the only way the money has a chance of coming back.

Section 29 - How to verify before you pay

Almost every scam in this book can be stopped by one habit: verify through a channel you found yourself, never one the other person gave you. Here is how to do that in under five minutes.

Before you...	Verify by...
Invest in a platform or adviser	Search the SEBI website for the registration. For a lender or NBFC, check the RBI's list of regulated entities.
Pay a UPI ID or merchant	Read the receiver's name on the payment screen and confirm it matches. If it is a random person's name, stop.
Trust a caller claiming to be your bank	Hang up and call the number printed on your card or passbook, or use the in-app support.
Use a 'company' website or app	Type the company's official address yourself, or open its app from the official store. Never use a link you were sent.
Act on a 'government' claim	Open the scheme's own official portal and check. Government benefits never need a fee or an OTP.
Buy from or sell to a stranger	Keep the transaction inside the platform, and wait for money to appear in your own account before handing anything over.

The five-minute rule

If anyone is rushing you, the correct response is always the same: stop, and verify through a channel you control. A genuine offer, job, refund or officer will survive five minutes of checking. A scam will not.

Section 30 - The family protocol: a code word and one rule

Fraudsters win by isolating one person and rushing them. A family that has agreed, in advance, how to behave under pressure is almost impossible to scam.

- 1 **Agree a family code word** that only your household knows, and use it if anyone ever calls claiming to be a relative in trouble.

- 2 **Agree one rule:** no money ever moves during an unexpected call, however urgent it sounds. Real emergencies survive a callback; scams do not.
- 3 **Teach your parents and grandparents** the digital-arrest script by name. Forewarning is the strongest defence - warn them before the call comes.
- 4 **Put 1930 on the fridge** and save it in every family phone.
- 5 **Be the person they call.** Tell them plainly that no matter what a caller says, they should call you first, and that you will never be angry at them for checking.

A one-page cyber-hygiene checklist you can finish today

Transaction alerts on. Limits set low. Savings account unlinked from UPI. Aadhaar biometrics locked. Phone and apps updated. Accessibility permissions reviewed. SIM PIN set. Family code word agreed. 1930 saved in every phone. Bank fraud helpline saved.

Part 4 - Fight Back (Recovery)

Section 31 - The Golden Hour: the first 60 minutes, step by step

If money has left your account, the next 60 minutes matter more than the next 60 days. Work down this list in order, without pausing to blame yourself.

- 1 **Stop the bleeding.** End the call. Do not pay anything more - no 'tax', no 'fee', no 'reversal payment'. Do not argue with the fraudster.
- 2 **Call 1930 immediately.** This is the National Cyber Crime Helpline. Tell the operator you want to report a financial cyber fraud and give them the details below. Every minute you wait, the money moves further.
- 3 **Have these ready:** your name, mobile number and address; your bank and account number; the amount and the date and time of the transaction; the transaction ID or UTR number; and the fraudster's UPI ID, account number or phone number if you have them.
- 4 **Call your bank's fraud helpline too,** through the number on your card or app. Ask them to flag the transaction as fraud and initiate a recall or lien on the receiving account. Get a complaint reference number.
- 5 **Note the acknowledgement number** the 1930 operator gives you. You need it for the next step.
- 6 **File the formal complaint at cybercrime.gov.in within 24 hours** using that acknowledgement number. This is what creates the record the police and banks act on.
- 7 **Preserve the evidence** (Section 38): screenshots of the chat, the call log, the payment screen, the fraudster's details.
- 8 **Report the number** on the Sanchar Saathi Chakshu facility (Section 34) so it can be flagged for others.

If you report within...	Your realistic chance
0 to 3 hours	Best. The money is often still in the system and can be caught.
3 to 24 hours	Possible. Some hops have happened; part may still be recoverable.
1 to 3 days	Difficult. Most funds have been withdrawn or layered away.
Beyond 3 days	Rare for the money itself, but still worth reporting - it builds the case and the data.

Five things not to do in the first hour

- Do not pay any more money, in any form, including a 'fee to reverse the transaction'.
- Do not delete the chat, the app or the call log - that is your evidence.
- Do not wait until you feel less embarrassed. Shame is the fraudster's ally; act first, feel later.
- Do not argue with or threaten the fraudster; it wastes the minutes that matter.
- Do not trust a 'recovery agent' who offers, for a fee, to get your money back - that is usually a second scam.

Section 32 - 1930 and cybercrime.gov.in: the exact walkthrough

These are the two official doors, and they work together. 1930 is the phone helpline, staffed by your state police, and it is the fastest route. cybercrime.gov.in is the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, where the formal complaint lives.

When you call 1930, the operator takes your details and raises a ticket inside CFCFRMS. That ticket is escalated automatically to your bank and to the bank or wallet that received the money. If the money is still there, it is put on hold (marked as a lien) so the fraudster cannot withdraw it. If it has moved to another account, the ticket follows it to the next bank, and so on. The chain only works if it starts fast.

After the call, you must file the formal complaint on cybercrime.gov.in within 24 hours, using the acknowledgement number you were given by SMS. The complaint is then forwarded to the concerned police station automatically - you do not have to visit one to get the process moving, though filing an FIR later (Section 37) strengthens your hand.

What the portal form asks for

- **Category:** choose the financial-fraud option that matches what happened (UPI, card, net banking, investment, job, and so on).
- **Suspect details:** the phone number, UPI ID, account number, email or social handle you have, and any link or app used.
- **Your details and the incident:** a short, factual, dated description in the order things happened.
- **Transaction details:** amount, date and time, transaction ID or UTR, and your bank and account.
- **Evidence:** attach the screenshots and any documents you saved.

Write these down before you need them

Helpline 1930 (24x7) | Portal cybercrime.gov.in | Police 100 / 112 | Bank fraud helpline (from your card) |
 Sanchar Saathi: sancharsaathi.gov.in | RBI Ombudsman: cms.rbi.org.in

Section 33 - Your bank, the lien, and RBI's liability rules

The Reserve Bank of India decides who bears the loss on an unauthorised electronic transaction, and the rules are more protective of customers than most people realise. The governing circular is 'Customer Protection - Limiting Liability of Customers in Unauthorised Electronic Banking Transactions' (6 July 2017).

Situation	Who bears the loss
Fraud caused by the bank's own negligence or a deficiency in its systems	Zero liability for the customer, whether or not you reported it.
A third-party breach (not the bank's fault, not yours), reported within 3 working days of the bank's communication	Zero liability.
Same third-party breach, reported within 4 to 7 working days	Limited: the lower of the transaction value or Rs 5,000 / Rs 10,000 / Rs 25,000, depending on account and card type.
Reported beyond 7 working days	As per the bank's Board-approved policy.
Loss due to your own negligence, such as sharing your credentials	You bear the loss up to the point you report it; the bank bears anything after you report.

Source: RBI circular DBR.No.Leg.BC.78/09.07.005/2017-18, dated 6 July 2017.

Three more protections are worth memorising. The bank must credit a shadow reversal of the disputed amount within 10 working days of your report. It must resolve the complaint and settle your liability within 90 days. And the burden of proving that you were liable lies on the bank, not on you. When you dispute a rejection, quote the 2017 circular by name and ask for the written reason and the specific policy clause relied on.

If the bank refuses or stalls

A refusal is not the end of the road; it is the start of the ladder in Section 37. Ask, in writing, for the rejection reason and the exact policy clause the bank relied on, and whether its Claims or Grievance committee approved it. Then send a fresh complaint to the bank's Grievance Redressal Officer, citing the 2017 circular and the 10-working-day reversal timeline. If 30 days pass without a satisfactory answer, file with the RBI Ombudsman at cms.rbi.org.in - it is free, it needs no lawyer, and it puts the bank on a regulator-visible clock. Keep every reply; each one becomes evidence at the next rung.

Section 34 - Reporting the number: Chakshu and Sanchar Saathi

Even if you lost no money, report the number that called you. The Department of Telecommunications runs Chakshu, a facility on the Sanchar Saathi portal, where you can report a suspected fraud call, SMS, WhatsApp message or suspicious web link. Reports made within 30 days are acted on.

This is not just symbolic. By early 2026, citizen inputs on Chakshu had helped disconnect 39.43 lakh mobile connections, blacklist 2.27 lakh handsets and blacklist 1.31 lakh SMS templates. Every report you file makes the next person's phone a little safer. Use Chakshu for attempted frauds; use 1930 for money actually lost.

Section 35 - If you shared Aadhaar, an OTP, or installed an app

Some frauds do not take money immediately - they take your identity or your access. If you showed your Aadhaar on a call, read out an OTP, or installed an app the fraudster asked for, act on these today.

- 1 **Lock your Aadhaar biometrics** on the UIDAI portal and check your authentication history for anything you do not recognise.
- 2 **Change passwords** on email and banking first, then everywhere else, and turn on two-factor authentication.
- 3 **Uninstall the app** the caller asked you to install, then scan the phone and review its permissions.
- 4 **Tell your bank** that your credentials may be exposed and ask them to review recent activity and, if needed, re-issue cards or reset access.
- 5 **Watch your accounts and credit** for the next few weeks. Check for loans or accounts opened in your name that you did not open.
- 6 **If an OTP was used, treat it as a fraud** and follow the Golden Hour steps in Section 31.

Section 36 - If your account or identity was taken over

Sometimes the fraud does not ask you for anything - it simply takes control. Account takeover and identity theft look different from the scams above, and they need their own response.

The signs

- You cannot log in, or your password has been changed without you.
- There are transactions you did not make, or a beneficiary you did not add.
- You get a loan approval, a credit card or a KYC message for a product you never applied for.
- Your credit report shows an account or enquiry you do not recognise.
- A one-time password arrives for a login you did not attempt.

What to do

- 1 **Call your bank's fraud line now** and ask them to freeze the account or the channel that was compromised, and to reset your access.
- 2 **Reset your email password first** (from a device you trust), then your banking password, then everywhere else, and enable two-factor authentication.
- 3 **Pull your credit report** and dispute anything you do not recognise with the credit bureau.
- 4 **Report the identity theft** on cybercrime.gov.in, and file a police complaint or FIR so there is an official record.

- 5 **Lock your Aadhaar biometrics** and watch your Aadhaar authentication history and your SIM registrations for a few weeks.

Section 37 - The recovery ladder: four rungs to get your money back

Freezing the money is automatic; returning it is not. Work up this ladder, one rung at a time, and keep every acknowledgement in writing.

Rung	Where	What to do
1. The bank's own grievance officer	Your bank's Grievance Redressal Officer (GRO), whose details must be on the bank's website	Send a written complaint (email counts) citing the transaction, the fraud, the RBI 2017 circular and the acknowledgement number. Keep the reference.
2. RBI Ombudsman (RB-IOS, 2021)	cms.rbi.org.in (free, 24x7)	If the bank does not resolve it within 30 days, or rejects it, file here. One Nation One Ombudsman - no fee, no lawyer needed. Contact centre 14448.
3. Consumer commission	e-Daakhil / e-Jagriti online filing	A wrongfully rejected claim is a 'deficiency in service' under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. You can claim the amount, interest and compensation.
4. Release of frozen funds (court)	The Judicial Magistrate with jurisdiction over the cyber crime unit	If money has been frozen in a fraudster's account, apply under Section 503 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (the old Section 457 CrPC) for release to you on an indemnity bond. The freeze power itself sits in Section 106 BNSS.

Also file an FIR or e-FIR at your nearest cybercrime police station. The portal complaint creates the record; an FIR creates a paper trail that strengthens every step above. In August 2026 the Supreme Court directed all states and courts to operationalise the MHA's grievance-redressal and money-restoration modules, and directed the RBI to issue banks a standard procedure for holding fraud-linked amounts - all of which makes the ladder above more likely to work than it did a year ago.

Section 38 - Evidence: what to preserve, and how

A fraud case is won or lost on evidence. Save these before you lose access to them.

- Screenshots of every chat, message and payment request, with the sender's number or ID visible.
- The call log showing the fraudster's number, and the time and duration of each call.
- The payment screen and the transaction ID or UTR number.
- The fraudster's UPI ID, bank account number, phone number, email or social handle.
- Any fake notice, document, video-call image or ID the caller showed you.
- Your bank statement showing the debit, and the acknowledgement number from 1930.
- A simple written timeline: what happened, in what order, with times.

Do not delete anything

Do not clear the chat, do not delete the call log, do not uninstall the fraud app before you have screenshotted it, and do not block the number until you have saved it. Evidence you destroy is evidence the police cannot use.

Section 39 - Ready-to-send templates**A. Email to your bank (fraud / recall request)****Copy, fill in the blanks, and send to your bank's official grievance email**

Subject: Fraudulent transaction on my account - request for recall and lien - Rs [amount] on [date]

Dear Sir/Madam, I wish to report an unauthorised transaction on my account [account number] on [date] at [time]. Amount: Rs [amount]. Transaction ID/UTR: [number]. The money was sent to [UPI ID / account number / name] as part of a cyber fraud, which I have reported on helpline 1930 (acknowledgement number [number]) and at cybercrime.gov.in. I request you to (1) immediately initiate a fraud recall and mark a lien on the receiving account, (2) treat this as a report under the RBI circular on Limiting Liability of Customers in Unauthorised Electronic Banking Transactions dated 6 July 2017, and (3) confirm in writing the action taken and the complaint reference. Kindly acknowledge this email. [Name, account, contact]

B. Complaint to the cybercrime portal / police (structure)**Use these headings in the complaint text box**

1. Complainant details (name, address, mobile, email). 2. Date, time and manner of the fraud (the script used). 3. Amount lost and transaction IDs. 4. Suspect details (numbers, IDs, accounts, links). 5. Evidence attached. 6. Relief sought: recovery of the amount and investigation. Keep it factual and in order.

C. RBI Ombudsman complaint (if the bank fails you)**File at cms.rbi.org.in - free, no lawyer**

State: the bank and branch; the transaction and date; that you reported it to the bank on [date] and received no satisfactory reply within 30 days; the RBI 2017 circular and the bank's duty to reverse within 10 working days; and the relief you seek (refund with interest). Attach the bank's replies and the 1930 acknowledgement.

D. What to say when you call 1930**Keep it short and factual**

"I want to report a financial cyber fraud. My name is [name], my bank is [bank], account [number]. I sent Rs [amount] to [UPI ID / account] on [date] at [time], transaction ID [number]. It was a [scam type] fraud. Please register the complaint and tell me the acknowledgement number." Then write the number down and file on cybercrime.gov.in within 24 hours.

Section 40 - The law: which section applies to what

You do not need to be a lawyer, but knowing which law applies helps you describe the crime correctly and push the right buttons. In practice, the police register most cyber frauds under both the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Information Technology Act, 2000.

Offence	Main provisions
Cheating / online financial fraud	Section 318 of the BNS, read with Section 66D of the IT Act.
Cheating by personation (fake profile, fake officer, fake seller)	Section 319 of the BNS, read with Section 66D of the IT Act.
Identity theft (misuse of passwords, signatures, unique IDs)	Section 66C of the IT Act.
Unauthorised access / hacking	Section 66 of the IT Act.
Freezing a suspect's account during investigation	Section 106 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023.
Releasing frozen money back to the victim	Section 503 of the BNSS (the old Section 457 CrPC) - the 'release of property' application.
Digital arrest as a named offence	Not yet defined in law; the Centre is preparing a Bill to make it (and AI deepfakes) standalone offences.

Two points worth carrying into any conversation with the police. First, the burden of proving a customer's liability in an unauthorised transaction lies on the bank (RBI, 2017). Second, the criminal laws and the IT Act are usually applied together, so it is normal - and correct - for an FIR to cite both.

Part 5 - Reference

Section 41 - Scam-by-scam action table

Scam	First action
Digital arrest call	Hang up. Do not pay. Call a family member. Report to 1930 if money moved.
Investment / trading fraud	Stop paying. Screenshot everything. 1930 + cybercrime.gov.in; check the platform's SEBI/RBI registration.
UPI QR / PIN trap	Screenshot the payment screen and UTR. Bank fraud helpline + 1930 within the hour.
OTP / KYC call	Never share. Hang up. If an OTP was used, treat as fraud and follow the Golden Hour.
Task / part-time job	Stop paying. Preserve the chats. Report to 1930 and the portal.
Fake customer care / screen-share	Uninstall the app. Change passwords. Report to 1930 if money moved.
Loan app harassment	Do not pay more. Report to 1930 and the police; keep the threats as evidence.
Sextortion	Do not pay. Stop contact. Report to 1930 / cybercrime.gov.in. Tell someone you trust.
Deepfake voice / video	Hang up. Call the person back on their saved number. Use your family code word.
Courier / e-challan / APK	Do not click or install. Report the link on Sanchar Saathi Chakshu.

Scam	First action
Card / ATM skimming	Block the card in the app now. Bank helpline + 1930. Cite the RBI 2017 circular.
Marketplace buyer / seller	Never scan or PIN to receive. Wait for money to show in your own app.
Scheme / subsidy / insurance	Never pay a fee or share an OTP. Check the official portal only.
Travel / education / job offer	Never pay through a private account. Verify the institution or employer.
Matrimonial / romance	Stop sending money. Preserve the chats. Report to 1930 and the portal.
Data shared (Aadhaar / OTP / app)	Lock Aadhaar biometrics, change passwords, uninstall the app, monitor accounts.

Section 42 - Case files: how three real frauds unfolded

These are the patterns behind reported cases, described generically so the lesson is what stays with you.

Case 1 - The deepfake investment (about Rs 18 lakh lost)

A school principal saw a video that appeared to feature a prominent business leader endorsing an investment platform. Impressed by the 'returns', she invested, then invested more. The profits on the dashboard were fake, and the money could not be withdrawn. Reported pattern: an AI-assisted investment scam using a fake platform, deepfaked content and fabricated investor groups. Lesson: a familiar face in a video proves nothing, and profits you cannot withdraw are not profits.

Case 2 - The golden-hour save (Rs 2.7 crore at stake, Rs 1.7 crore recovered)

A woman entrepreneur in Bengaluru lost Rs 2.7 crore to cyber criminals over about two weeks. The moment she realised, she called 1930 and filed a complaint. Police traced and froze about Rs 1.7 crore in mule accounts, and another Rs 30 lakh was found soon after. Lesson: speed to 1930 is what turns a total loss into a partial recovery.

Case 3 - The digital arrest that failed

A retired government employee received a call from someone claiming to be a CBI officer, accusing him of money laundering and sending fake arrest documents. He became suspicious when he was asked to transfer money through UPI, stopped, and reported it to the police. Lesson: the request for money is the tell. No genuine officer asks for a UPI transfer.

The pattern across all three

Every one of these cases turned on a single moment: whether the victim paid, and how fast they acted once they stopped. The technology changes; the defence is the same - recognise the request, refuse it, and report fast.

Section 43 - Official helplines and portals

What you need	Where to go
Report financial cyber fraud / lost money	Helpline 1930 (24x7) and cybercrime.gov.in

What you need	Where to go
Report a suspected fraud call, SMS or link	Sanchar Saathi - Chakshu: sancharsaathi.gov.in/sfc
Police emergency	100 or 112
Your bank's fraud / grievance desk	The number on your card or in the bank's app; the bank's Grievance Redressal Officer
Complain against a bank / NBFC / payment firm	RBI Ombudsman: cms.rbi.org.in (free); contact centre 14448
Consumer complaint	e-Daakhil / e-Jagriti online consumer commission filing
Lock Aadhaar biometrics, check history	UIDAI portal (uidai.gov.in)
Check a broker / adviser is registered	SEBI website (sebi.gov.in)
Report a fraudulent loan app	cybercrime.gov.in ; also I4C's Sahyog route for app blocking

Section 44 - The 30-day family cyber-safety plan

Do one thing a day for a month, and your household becomes a hard target.

Week	Focus
Week 1 - Lock the accounts	Transaction alerts on; limits set low; savings account unlinked from UPI; old beneficiaries removed; card channels switched off; bank fraud helpline saved.
Week 2 - Lock the phone and identity	Update OS and apps; remove unknown apps; audit permissions; lock Aadhaar biometrics; check Aadhaar history; set up app-based 2FA; set a SIM PIN.
Week 3 - Lock the family	Agree a code word; teach elders the digital-arrest script; put 1930 on the fridge; rehearse the 'no money during an unexpected call' rule.
Week 4 - Lock the habit	Walk through the 12 red flags together; save the official numbers; write the recovery steps on one card and keep it with the family documents.

Section 45 - Frequently asked questions

Is there really no such thing as a digital arrest?

Correct. No Indian law allows anyone to be arrested or investigated over a phone or video call, and no agency asks you to transfer money to avoid arrest. As of late 2026 the government is drafting a Bill to make digital arrest a standalone offence, but the scam itself has never been legal process.

Can I get my money back?

Sometimes - and it depends almost entirely on speed. If you report to 1930 within a few hours, the money is often still in the system and can be frozen. Returning frozen money to you takes longer and requires persistence, but the mechanisms (the MHA money-restoration module and the Section 503 BNSS application) exist.

The bank says it is my fault because I approved the payment. Is that the end?

No. The RBI's 2017 circular sets out when you have zero liability and when liability is limited, and it puts the burden of proof on the bank. Ask for the rejection in writing with the exact policy clause, then escalate to the Grievance Redressal Officer and, if needed, the RBI Ombudsman.

Should I pay a small amount to 'unlock' my withdrawal?

Never. That request is the fraud. No genuine platform, employer or agency asks you to pay money to release your own money.

I shared my OTP. What now?

Treat it as a fraud the moment it happens: call 1930 and your bank immediately, change your passwords, and follow Section 35. Speed is everything.

Do I need a lawyer to file with the RBI Ombudsman?

No. Filing with the RBI Ombudsman is free and you can do it yourself at cms.rbi.org.in. You may use a representative, but you do not have to, and you should never pay a third-party 'recovery agent' - those are often a second scam.

Someone is threatening to leak my video. Will paying stop it?

Almost never. Paying confirms you will pay and invites more demands. Stop contact, preserve the evidence and report to 1930 or cybercrime.gov.in, which handles these cases with confidentiality. You have done nothing wrong.

I lost nothing - should I still report?

Yes. Report the number on Sanchar Saathi's Chakshu facility. It takes two minutes and helps get that number disconnected before it reaches someone who does pay.

Are these frauds only in big cities?

No. NCRB data shows cyber crime spreading deep into smaller towns and rural districts, and the government's own figures show growing participation from beyond the metros. The phone in a small town is as reachable as the one in a metro.

Section 46 - Glossary

Term	What it means
NCRP	National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in), where you file cybercrime complaints.
CFCFRMS	Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System - the back-end that connects 1930 reports to banks and wallets to freeze money fast.
I4C	Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre, the Ministry of Home Affairs body that runs NCRP and CFCFRMS.
1930	The national cyber-crime financial-fraud helpline.
Mule account	A bank account rented or sold by an ordinary person and used to receive and move fraud money.
Lien	A hold a bank places on money in an account so it cannot be withdrawn while a fraud is investigated.
UTR	Unique Transaction Reference - the number that identifies a specific bank or UPI transfer.
UPI PIN	The password that authorises money to leave your account. Never needed to receive money.
P2P collect request	A discontinued UPI feature that let one person ask another to pay; a common old fraud vector.
Chakshu	The DoT facility on Sanchar Saathi to report suspected fraud calls, SMS and links.
RB-IOS	The Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021 - the free route to escalate a bank complaint.
BNSS	Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 - the criminal procedure law. Section 106 covers freezing, Section 503 the release of frozen money.
BNS	Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 - the penal law. Section 318 covers cheating, Section 319 cheating by personation.
Sextortion	Blackmail using a recorded video or image of the victim, usually captured during an unsolicited video call.

Section 47 - What scammers are pushing right now

Fraud follows the calendar. As this playbook is published, in October 2026, the festive season is the backdrop, and a few scam types are running hot.

- **Fake festive-sale links.** Messages and ads that look like big-sale offers but lead to look-alike sites or apps that capture your card details. Shop only inside the official marketplace app you opened yourself.
- **Fake delivery and 'order problem' calls.** A caller claims your festive order is stuck and needs a small fee or a link to 're-confirm' the address. Genuine couriers do not ask for fees or links.
- **Festive travel and hotel frauds.** Discounted tickets or stays, then a 'cancellation refund' call that wants your card details. Book through recognised platforms or the provider directly.

- **Year-end investment pitches.** 'Limited-time' schemes promising big returns before the year closes. Urgency is the tell, and investment fraud is still the single biggest loss-maker.
- **Bonus and gift scams.** Messages about a festival bonus, a lucky draw or a gift that need a fee or an OTP to claim. Genuine gifts do not need your PIN or an advance payment.

The seasonal detail changes; the shape does not. Anything that combines urgency, a link you were sent, and a request for money, an OTP or a PIN is the same scam wearing a festival hat.

Section 48 - The one-page quick-reference card

Photograph this page, or copy it onto a card and keep it with your important documents.

If a fraud is happening right now

1. Hang up. Do not pay anything more. 2. Call 1930 immediately with your account number, the amount, and the transaction ID. 3. Call your bank's fraud line and ask for a recall and a lien. 4. Note the 1930 acknowledgement number. 5. File the formal complaint at cybercrime.gov.in within 24 hours. 6. Save every screenshot and the call log.

The numbers to save in every family phone

Cyber fraud helpline: 1930 | Cybercrime portal: cybercrime.gov.in | Police: 100 or 112 | Sanchar Saathi (report a fraud number): sancharsaathi.gov.in | RBI Ombudsman: cms.rbi.org.in | Your bank's fraud line: from your card or app.

The 12 red flags in one line each

Digital arrest over a call. Money to a 'safe' account. Secrecy from family. Any request for an OTP, PIN, password or CVV. Scan or PIN to receive money. Install a screen-share app. Click a link or install an .apk. Guaranteed returns or a fee to withdraw. A job that asks you to pay. A sudden urgent call from your bank or a courier. A relative in trouble you cannot reach. Anyone rushing you.

Section 49 - A word for anyone who has been scammed

If you have already lost money, this section is for you, and it is short. You are not stupid, and you are not alone. The people behind these frauds are professionals who do this for a living, who study how to make fear and hope override judgement, and who win because they reach thousands of people and only need to succeed once. Falling for one is not a character flaw; it is the predictable result of a well-built trap.

What matters now is not blame but action. Report to 1930 quickly, keep pushing up the recovery ladder, and tell one person you trust - because the shame that keeps people silent is the same shame that keeps the money with the fraudster. Every case that is reported makes the system a little better at catching the next one, and every story shared warns someone before their phone rings. You did the right thing by reading this far. Now do the two things that help: report, and warn the people you love.

The Indian Cyber Fraud Survival Playbook - Digital Edition. Published by digitalkartai.shop. Facts verified from the Ministry of Home Affairs, I4C, RBI, NPCI, the Department of Telecommunications and Supreme Court directions, October 2026. This is an information product and not legal or financial advice.